the BJP finished as the second largest party with forty-eight seats in the Greater Hyderabad municipal polls. Furthermore, it finished within striking distance of the ruling TRS, which went down drastically to fifty-five seats.[123] The BJP's stunning rise in Hyderabad's 2020 municipal poll demonstrated yet again the fresh inroads the party was now making in the state.

Rajeev Chandrashekhar told me, 'In the South, there is a simple issue you cannot hide. South is an issue of political leaders. If we had an Amit Shah in the South; or we had an Arun Jaitley in the South who speaks Tamil, who speaks Malayalam, we would do better. The other problem in the South is that, unlike in the North—where there's one Hindi link language—the South has multiple languages. So, if I'm a leader from UP, I can work across North India. Here you have Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam, Konkani and many other languages. It is not so easy for one leader.' So, what did the party need, I asked him. 'We need five leaders, five solid local leaders,' he responded. 'Those local leaders have not developed yet. In Karnataka, we have a good bench-strength. But in Telangana, Tamil Nadu or Kerala, the focus now of our PM is that he will build these good, solid local leaders who will be able to communicate, take the message.' The BJP's aim, he pointed out, was to replace the Congress in the southern states. He too saw Telangana as a 'big opportunity'. 'KCR is vulnerable and Telangana is good hunting ground for BJP because Congress is diminished here. Chandrababu Naidu is non-existent, so BJP naturally can be a counter to KCR. Similarly, in Andhra, there's only YSR-Congress. Now that Congress is disappearing in Andhra and N. Chandrababu Naidu, in my opinion, is at the end of his political career, we have a huge opportunity to expand here.'[124]

By 2021, the political chessboard of Kerala too looked like Karnataka's from the early 1990s. Kerala had at least five Lok Sabha constituencies (of a total of twenty) where the BJP had been consistently winning over 20 per cent of the vote share. In the south: Thiruvananthapuram (31.3 per cent), Attingal (24.7 per cent) and Pathanamthitta (29.7 per cent), the centre of the Sabarimala agitation; in central Kerala: Thrissur (28.7 per cent) and Palakkad (21.3 per cent); and in the north, Kasargod (16 per cent).[125] In these